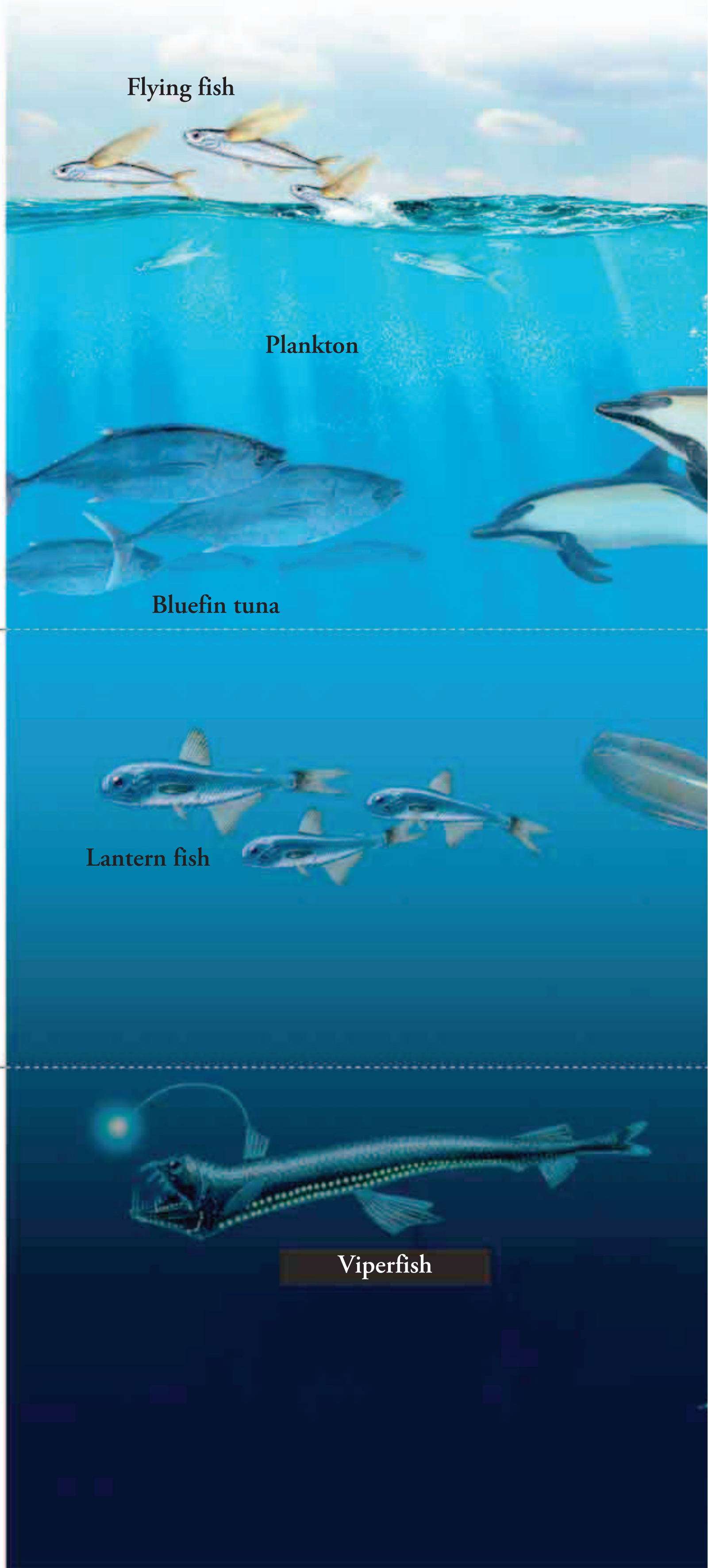
Depth zones

The world's oceans have an average depth of almost 13,000 ft (4,000 m). But several feet below the surface, their nature starts changing dramatically because of the way the light fades with depth. From the glittering, sunlit surface to the permanent darkness of the deep ocean, the dwindling light affects visibility, color, temperature, and the availability of food.



SUNLIT ZONE

The top 660 ft (200 m) are often called the sunlit zone. Here the water is lit up with enough sunlight to support the plantlike plankton that need light to live and multiply. Since these are the main source of food in the oceans, this is where most marine animals live.

Sunlit zone
0–660 ft
(0–200 m)

TWILIGHT ZONE

Below 660 ft (200 m) there is not enough light to support the organisms that rely on it for energy. The only light filtering down from the surface is a faint blue glow, so this part of the ocean is called the twilight zone. Animals live here, but far fewer than in the sunlit zone.

Twilight zone
660–3,300 ft
(200–1,000 m)

DARK ZONE

Below 3,300 ft (1,000 m) there is no light at all, aside from the eerie glow produced by some deep-sea animals in this dark zone. Since the oceans are, on average, four times as deep as this—and often much deeper—most of the world's ocean water is in total darkness.

Dark zone
Below 3,300 ft
(1,000 m)